

A note to mySociety — a draft, kept in the open

Like everything in this project, the letter is public before it is sent: github.com/GlassOnTin/civic-kernel. Direct contact details travel with the sent copy, not the repo.

Two of your tools sit exactly where a design study I've been running kept arriving, and I wanted you to have the evidence, because it is partly evidence about your own work.

The study rebuilt sixty-one documented institutional failures — Horizon, the deleted WhatsApps, the FOI Clearing House, the carer prosecuted for a debt the state watched grow — as machine-checked case files, each asking one narrow question: *which record, required at which moment, citing which rule, would have changed this?* Every file cites its sources (168 real-world citations across the corpus) and ends in an honest verdict; eight of the sixty-one are marked **breaks**, because the method counts its own failures.

WhatDoTheyKnow is halfway through one of the corpus's strongest findings. The FOI case file concludes that every slow-walking lever — the missed deadline, the stacked public-interest extension, the profiled requester — acts on the *request*, so the end-state is a record public by default, with nothing left to request. Your platform already does the first half at scale: it makes the request and the response public, which is what turned slow-walking from a private frustration into a measurable pattern. The case file is, in effect, the argument for where that road ends — and the sixty-one-case corpus is evidence your FOI work could cite.

FixMyStreet is the citizen's half of a shape the corpus met twice and named. Two case files — Grenfell's ignored hazard reports, and SEND assessment requests rationed by delay — reduce to the same missing structure: an inbound report should produce a dated receipt, the receipt should start a duty-clock, and a breached clock should carry a consequence by default. Your platform already produces the public, dated report and makes the silence visible. What the corpus adds is the name for the missing half — the duty-clock with a default on breach — and the documented cost of its absence.

Both findings, with ten others, are staged into a [roadmap for UK law](#) (publication by default is step five; self-enforcing deadlines step six), each step grounded in its cases. The corpus itself is at [scenarios](#), the synthesis at [map](#), and the method — including how cases are chosen and refused — at [triage](#).

The ask is small: a look, and corrections. If your research team finds the encoding method useful, or finds it wrong somewhere, either is valuable — the case files are public data and the door for proposing or disputing a case is [open](#). Nothing here is commercial, and nothing is asked beyond that.

[Sender: name and contact line added on sending.]